



Like a chameleon!

OnePlus' latest concept phone can change its colour in sync with your breathing; advanced motion tracking. <http://dgit.in/jan21-49>



Apple Car 2024

Apple to build its first self-driving car in 2024, with "next-level" battery technology to increase vehicle's range. <http://dgit.in/jan21-50>

Google Nest Audio

Makes better audio more accessible

It's been four years since Google launched its first smart speaker - the Google Home - then Google acquired Nest to fuel its smart home ambitions and released a few more iterations of its smart speakers, followed by the latest Google Nest Audio. Which also means Google now has the Nest Mini, Nest Hub and Nest audio, a much better proposition to take on Amazon's wide range of Echo devices. As the name suggests, the Nest Audio is focused on bringing a richer audio output to make it suitable for music listeners and serve a larger customer base. It retails at ₹7,999, making it an impressive option for a price-sensitive market like India.

Design and build

If you've seen the previous Google Home and Google Nest speakers, you will immediately be able to tell that the Nest Audio comes from the same family. It has a very simplistic, minimalist and neutral look, just what we've seen on the company's smart speakers in the past. The front is seamless, it has nothing except for the four LEDs that light up when you interact with the speaker. If you've seen the Google Home Max, it's the same shape but one-third of its size. It's less than 7 inches tall and only 3 inches thick. It has Google's signature mesh cloth wrapped around the body with a single seam running around the sides, joining at the flat rubberized bottom with a 'G' (Google logo) in the centre. The Nest Audio has a very solid construction, weighing just over 1 kg. The minimalism pans all over the body as it only has a body-coloured mute switch, Google logo and the DC power port at the back.



Price
₹7,999

Smart Home features

It works just as any other Google Assistant-based smart speaker, maybe a bit faster because of the newer chip. It lets you do basic tasks like setting reminders, booking an Uber, controlling IoT-based appliances and telling weather and jokes. The speaker also has Chromecast built-in, which worked just as intended when we tried to stream videos and music on a smart TV. It can also be used as a standalone Bluetooth speaker in case you lose Wi-Fi. You just have to command the Assistant to "pair Bluetooth" and it will automatically go into pairing mode.

Audio performance

The Nest Audio packs a 75 mm woofer and a 19 mm tweeter. Since it carries 'Audio' in its name, one is bound to have high expectations in this department. For its size, the Nest Audio sounds pretty impressive. It has a loud and clear sound for all kinds of media from spoken word to the music. This is not a party speaker, but it's as good as any other single-body compact speaker of its price. We

went through a wide gamut of genres including unmastered bhajans to Led Zeppelin. But at times when playing a song like Radiohead's 'The National Anthem' you might want to tweak the equaliser manually to get the right balance. Even at half volume, the mids and lows are well reproduced. If you're a fan of harmonic instruments, vocals and electronic music you are more likely to enjoy this. Or if you listen to a lot of podcasts, this speaker will give you no chance to complain there either.

Microphone performance

A microphone is as important if not more than the speaker performance on voice-enabled gadgets. Thankfully, Google doesn't disappoint here. Be it picking up voice, recognition or responding to it, the speaker feels more user-friendly and a step closer to making it more realistic.

During our review which went over 25 days and there wasn't a single instance where we found ourselves struggling with a command. We can't say the same for folks interacting in Hindi. There's also a lot of work left to be done in Hindi recognition, given the variety in tone and accent across the breadth of the country. The only instance where we had to raise our voice a bit is when the volume was over 7, which we find reasonable.

Verdict

The Nest Audio is affordable, elegant and a great-sounding compact smart speaker for any room or a hall. Compared to the original Google Home launched more than two years ago at a slightly higher price, the Nest Audio looks like an incremental upgrade in all departments at a lesser price point.

—Sudhanshu Singh

SPECIFICATIONS

DISPLAY: AMOLED | RESOLUTION: 326ppi | OS: WearOS | SoC: Snapdragon Wear 3100 | RAM: 1 GB | STORAGE: 8 GB | BLUETOOTH: 4.2.

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